

One of the oldest and well-known networking hardware companies is reinventing its image in the Indian market. We speak with Kartik Bakshi, Country Manager for India at Belkin International to see how Linksys is working to achieve this vision.

Q What are you doing to change Linksys' perception in the Indian market?

Kartik: Linksys has always been perceived as a high-end premium router brand. A company that sells quality products at a premium. If you compare Linksys' portfolio to some of the other competitors that have higher market share than us, then their products might not be of the same quality or have the same feature set as Linksys but their price points are very acceptable to the Indian consumer. And if someone was looking towards buying an aspirational product, then that's where Linksys was fitting in. However, that was how the brand was operating earlier. Over the past 12 months, ever since I took over Linksys, my main aim was, and I'm quoting this in Hindi, "Jo dikhta hai, woh bikta hai". At the same time, we had to look at price points that were acceptable to the customer. So what we started doing was that we started focusing on marketing speed, performance, dead spots, extensibility, etc. and at the same time we were focusing on bringing products that were more acceptable to the Indian consumer. For example, we brought in an AC1200 router for an MSRP of INR 3000 and it sells for that much on Amazon. Even though it was great to be perceived as an aspirational brand we wanted to adopt a similar strategy as what Mercedes has wherein they have the E-Class, S-Class and other tiers. So we have high-end routers for those who want premium features, we're looking at gamers and enthusiasts, but for the ordinary consumer we have more products that are acceptable to the Indian market.

Q So how did you go about achieving this? The expensive chipsets do cost a premium which is passed down to the consumer. Where did you cut costs to make the products more appealing to the ordinary consumer?

Kartik: We've started these E-series 802.11 AC and AX routers which are more budget friendly. On some of our routers, we aren't providing the app. For example, if you buy our AC1200 router then you will not get the Linksys app. However, if you

buy the high-end Velop or MR-series routers then you get the app which gives you access to parental controls, anti-virus and more features that enhance the user experience. We don't really change the quality and the components as such. We keep focusing on the newest technology. So once Wi-Fi 6 came out, Linksys was globally focusing on enhancing our portfolio in the Wi-Fi 6 family. And as you know, the newest technology is usually the most expensive. But our focus for India was clear-cut in that we don't want to focus purely on the newest technology but bring in technology that is more relevant in India. And partnering with a company like Foxconn which has the manufacturing capability and scalability has helped bring the cost down overall. To answer your question, apart from the app, everything else i.e. the features, components, etc are all the same.

Q I remember testing one of your E-series routers (EA7500) about two years ago and found that the European models had Qualcomm chipsets (IPQ8064) but the Indian models had MediaTek chipsets (MT7621AT).

Kartik: For all the routers that we make, we use the same chipsets. We will never use different chipsets. I'll have to double-check on this and get back to you but we do use the same chipsets across the same model no matter which country it goes to. There are some models which are specific to EU or NA markets and similarly, there are some products that are specific

to asian markets. But if the models are selling across different regions then they'll be using the same chipset.

Q With regards to partnering with Foxconn, are you manufacturing any of your routers in Foxconn's Indian factories?

Kartik: So far we haven't done anything Made in India yet, however, we are working on it. Foxconn just purchased Belkin a couple of years ago and the integration, even though complete, is still going on. I'm expecting that we can hopefully start making things in India for India and other regions. As you know duties and taxes have such a huge impact on prices in India so we have to factor those into our vision. I don't see anything happening this year but being an Indian and being part of such a huge corporation, it's my dream to get the Make in India project over the next couple of years to benefit the Indian market and other markets as well. **Q**

Not just premium



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Linksys is going mainstream with its networking products and we get all the details

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